schedules, devices—feeds into decisions about what someone can do, when, and under what circumstances.

This relational view highlights why authorization deserves its own discipline. It is not just about securing resources; it is about governing interactions between entities, grounded in the terms of their relationships and mediated by policy. This perspective reframes authorization not as an afterthought to authentication but rather as the primary mechanism by which digital relationships are honored—or denied—in real time.

4.3 Speaking authorization: key concepts and terms

In the previous section, we saw how authorization operationalizes identity relationships, turning them into real-time decisions about who can do what. To do this effectively, we need a shared language.

Let's begin by clarifying a common source of confusion: access control versus authorization.

- *Access control* is the discipline or strategy focused on managing access to systems, data, or resources. It includes all the policies, rules, and mechanisms that determine who can access what, when, and under what conditions.
- *Authorization*, by contrast, is the mechanism that enforces access decisions based on identity, attributes, and policy. It serves as the aspect of access control that addresses this question: Should this action be allowed right now, under these conditions?

Put simply, access control defines the strategy, while authorization is the method of enforcement.

4.3.1 The PARC model

To help us discuss the various components of an authorization decision consistently, we will use a mental model called PARC, which stands for *p*rincipal, *a*ction, *r*esource, and *c*onditions. In any access decision, someone